

P A R I S H I S T O R Y T O U R S

World War II & The French Resistance

Left Bank Self-Guided Tour

Fall • Resistance • Liberation

A 2 km walking tour — approx. 1.5 hours
4 stops • 3 districts • Left Bank of Paris

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How to use this guide

This document is the self-guided version of the WWII Left Bank Tour. Take your time, read at your own pace, and stop wherever you like to look around. The whole route is roughly 2 km — about 30 minutes of pure walking, but plan around 1.5 hours with reading and stops.

This self-guided version covers the full historical arc of the tour. But the small stories, human anecdotes and digressions I share while walking — those I keep for the live tour. If you enjoy this and want the fuller experience, come walk it with me in person.

The route

4 main stops on the Left Bank, crossing 3 districts: the 5th, the 6th, and finishing opposite Notre-Dame on the Île de la Cité. Between the main stops, several "interstops" — short pauses at specific spots where there is something to see without a long story attached.

- **Stop 1 — 60 Boulevard Saint-Michel (Context of war)**
- **Stop 2 — Palais du Luxembourg (Fall of Paris)**
- Interstop — Théâtre de l'Odéon (plaque to Jacques Guierre)
- **Stop 3 — Corner of Rue Monsieur-le-Prince and Rue de Vaugirard (Resistance — Agnès Humbert)**
- Interstops — Sorbonne façade, Observatory tower, Saint-Séverin
- **Stop 4 — Facing Notre-Dame (Liberation — Préfecture de Police)**

The visual cues

Along the way you will see four kinds of boxes:



WHERE YOU STAND

These boxes tell you exactly where to position yourself and what to look for around you.



A question to think about before reading on

→ And then the answer, with the historical detail behind it.



WALK — Walking directions to the next stop.

A note from the guide

I built this tour over years of reading and walking. I am not an academic — I am a passionate enthusiast, and what I share with you is the story as I have come to understand it.

If something doesn't make sense, or if you spot something I got wrong, please write to me. The tour gets better every time someone pushes back on it.

STOP 1

Context of War

60 Boulevard Saint-Michel — How we ended up at war in 1939



WHERE YOU STAND

You are standing in front of 60 Boulevard Saint-Michel, in the 5th arrondissement, just south of the Sorbonne and a short walk from the Panthéon.

Look up at the façade. You will see bullet holes peppering the stone — all the way up to the top floor. The building was requisitioned by the German army during the Occupation, and these scars are from the fighting during the Liberation of Paris in August 1944. They are real, untouched, and a fitting place to begin.

A few hundred metres behind you sits the Panthéon, where Jean Moulin — the most important figure of the French Resistance — lies entombed. It felt right to start the tour here, between bullet holes and Jean Moulin.

Welcome

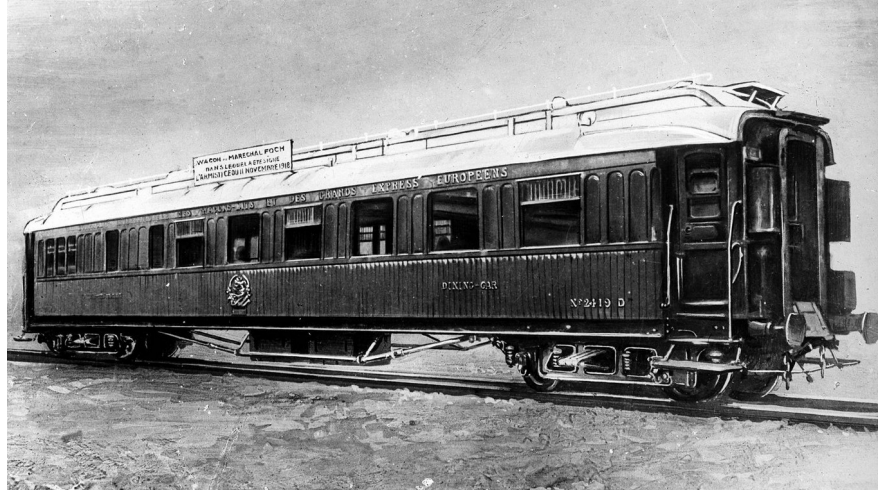
Thank you for being here. If you're reading this guide, it probably means you're curious about both Paris and the Second World War — and this tour is designed to bring the two together.

We'll do 4 main stops along 2 km, with a few short interstops along the way. This first stop — this one — is a "catch-up" on how we ended up at war in 1939. The next will cover the fall of Paris. Stop 3 will tell the story of the first Paris resistance network through the eyes of Agnès Humbert. And we'll finish at Notre-Dame, with the Liberation.

Let's go back to basics.

From Versailles to Munich

The First World War ends in 1918. The Germans sign the armistice inside a railway carriage in the forest of Compiègne. The following year, they are forced to sign the Treaty of Versailles — a treaty that brings Germany to its knees.



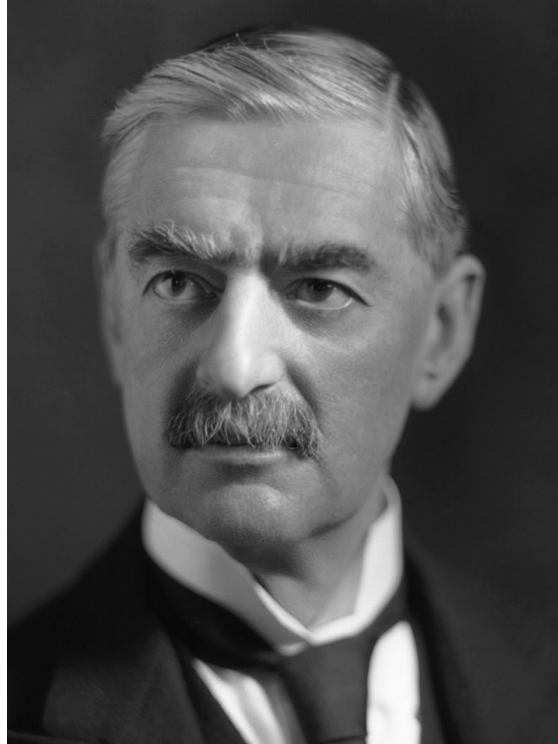
The carriage in the Compiègne forest where the 1918 armistice was signed. Hitler would force the French to sign the 1940 armistice in the same carriage.

? Do you know the three main types of sanction the treaty imposed on Germany?

→ Territorial: Germany lost 15% of its land and all its colonies. Financial: 132 billion gold marks in reparations — equivalent to 47 kilotons of gold, or three times the current annual budget of the French state. Military: no more armoured vehicles, no air force, and the army capped at 100,000 men.

These sanctions stirred a powerful desire for revenge in Germany. The 1929 crash drove poverty and unemployment through the roof, fascism spread, and Hitler seized power in January 1933 — exactly ten years after his failed putsch attempt. Once in power, he started tearing up the Versailles Treaty piece by piece: refusing to pay what was owed, and above all rebuilding the German army.

France and the UK responded with pacifism. The central figure here is the British Prime Minister Neville Chamberlain. He wanted to preserve peace at almost any cost. Every time Hitler broke a clause of the treaty, the French and British said: "We're not going to war over this. Peace matters more."



Neville Chamberlain — British Prime Minister and the face of pre-war appeasement.

This way of thinking peaked at the Munich Agreement.

? Do you know what the Munich Agreement was, and when it was signed?

→ In September 1938, Hitler and Chamberlain (along with France and Italy) shook hands over a region of Czechoslovakia called the Sudetenland — a part of the country with a large German-speaking population. Hitler was given the green light to take it. Chamberlain came home waving the agreement, proud of his "peace for our time." Six months later, Hitler broke the treaty and invaded the rest of Czechoslovakia by force.



Hitler and Chamberlain at Munich, September 1938.



"I have here a paper..." Chamberlain returns from Munich, the agreement in hand.

Finally, the French and the British changed their minds. They decided Poland was the red line Hitler could not cross. And when Hitler invaded Poland anyway on 1 September 1939, France and the UK declared war two days later, on 3 September.



German troops crossing into Poland, 1 September 1939 — the start of the Second World War.

 **WALK** — Head north on Boulevard Saint-Michel and enter the Luxembourg Gardens straight through the main entrance. Walk through the gardens towards the Palais du Luxembourg — about 5 minutes. Stand on the side facing the palace, with a clear view of the façade.

STOP 2

The Fall of Paris

Palais du Luxembourg — How Paris fell in 35 days



WHERE YOU STAND

You are standing in front of the Palais du Luxembourg, home of the French Senate since 1799 — and in 1940, the seat of the upper house of Parliament.

It was here, on 21 May 1940, that Prime Minister Paul Reynaud gave one of the most important speeches of the entire war — the speech that told the French people that the situation was catastrophic.

We'll come back to that speech in a few minutes. First, let's set the scene.

The drôle de guerre — Paris during the "phoney war"

At the last stop we left things on 3 September 1939, the day France and the UK declared war on Germany. Everything changed in Paris that day — theatres, cinemas, and music halls all closed immediately. Sandbags went up around monuments. Gas masks were distributed.

But on the front, almost nothing happened. Poland was crushed in a month, with Soviet help. But on the Western front, the Germans did not attack. Life in Paris slowly returned to normal — cinemas and theatres reopened, restaurants filled again. The French called this period the *drôle de guerre*, the "phoney war." It lasted eight months.

Paul Reynaud and the first restrictions

On 26 February 1940, the first German reconnaissance plane flew directly over Paris. That was a turning point. The new Prime Minister Paul Reynaud, who had taken office a month earlier, knew that war was inevitable — and he started preparing Parisians for it.



Paul Reynaud, Prime Minister of France from March 1940. He saw the war coming clearly — earlier than most.

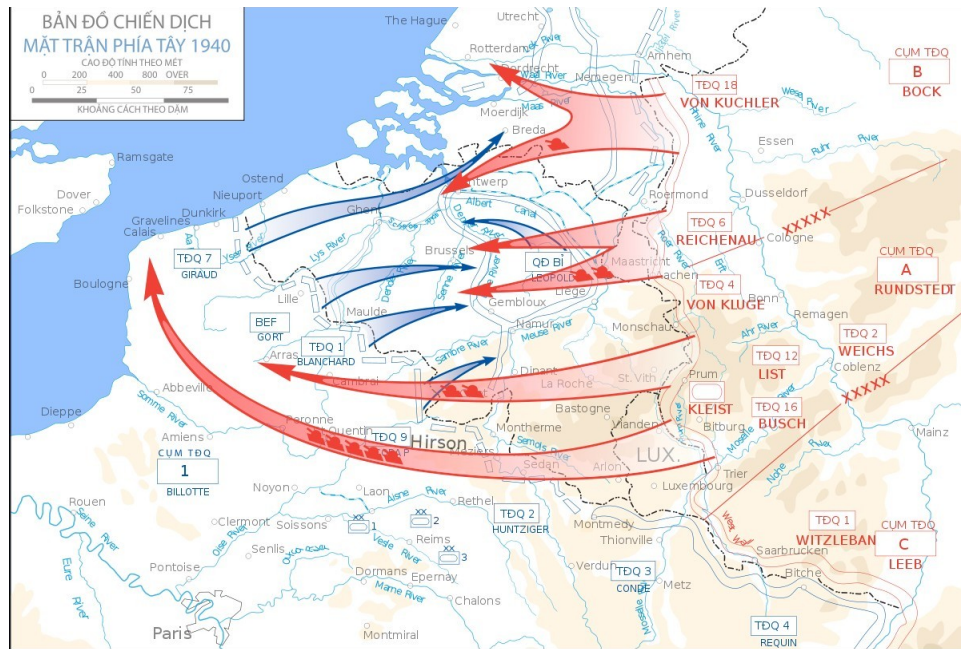
? From 1 April 1940, what changed for the people of Paris?

→ Food restrictions began. Special breads (raisin bread, milk bread) were banned. Butter disappeared from restaurant tables. Bakeries and butcher shops opened on alternating days of the week. None of this was dramatic yet — but it was a clear signal that the easy months were over.

And on 10 May 1940, the easy months ended for good.

10 May 1940 — The German offensive

Look at the map. Two phases to understand:



The German offensive of May 1940. The dummy attack through Belgium and the Netherlands drew the French army north — while the real attack came lower, through the Ardennes.

Phase 1: The Germans attack in Belgium and the Netherlands — exactly as the French commander-in-chief, General Maurice Gamelin, had predicted. He moves one million men north to meet them.



General Maurice Gamelin — commander-in-chief of the French army in May 1940.

Phase 2: On 13 May, the Germans attack lower — through the Ardennes forest, which the French generals had declared "impassable" by armoured columns. Using a combined force of tanks and Stuka dive-bombers, they cross the Ardennes and the Meuse river in two days, slicing through the thin French defensive line in that region.

And just like that, the road to Paris is open.

15-16 May 1940 — The Great Fear

On 15 May at 6 a.m., the Minister of Defence calls Paul Reynaud — he is the only person in the government who really understands what has just happened. His words: "Everything is lost. The road to Paris is open. There is nothing left to stop the Germans from reaching the capital."

Reynaud spends 15 May assessing the damage. On 16 May at 9 a.m., he convenes an emergency war committee at the Ministry of Foreign Affairs on the Quai d'Orsay, just across the river from where we are now.

? What three urgent questions do you think dominated that meeting?

→ One — evacuate the government? Two — evacuate the population? Three — what to do with all the classified documents in Paris, especially in the ministries? The meeting was chaotic. The Ministry of Transport admitted it had neither the trucks nor the trains to move the government within two days. So it was decided that the government would stay until the very last moment, and the few trucks available would be used to move the archives.

But as the meeting was coming to a close, people in the room began to hear muffled noises from the courtyard outside. The employees of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs were dumping every classified file out of the windows and into the courtyard. Once the pile was high enough, they poured petrol on it and set it on fire. The order to burn the files had come from the Secretary General of the Ministry, Alexis Léger, who knew there was no way to evacuate 100 tonnes of archives in time.

And then, on the night of 16 May, the news came in: the Germans were not heading for Paris. They were heading for the coast, to trap the Allied armies in the north.

The press kept the public in the dark

A crucial point: while all this was unfolding inside the government, the people of Paris had absolutely no idea how bad things were. Censorship saw to that. The newspaper front page from 16 May — the day the government was burning its own archives — told Parisians the Germans had been "halted" and that "strong counter-attacks" were underway. None of it was true.

3 June — Paris is bombed

Many people think Paris was never bombed in the Second World War, because it was declared an open city. That's true — but only from 12 June. On 3 June 1940, German bombers struck factories in the 15th arrondissement. More than 250 people died.



The aftermath of the bombing of Paris, 3 June 1940.

On 10 June, Italy declared war on France. The German armies were now at the gates of the city. By the evening of the 10th, every minister had fled Paris.

And so had the Parisians. No clear instructions had been given to the population — but the exodus was massive. Of the 2.8 million Parisians, only around 700,000 stayed. About 75% of the population had fled by 14 June.

14 June 1940 — The Germans enter Paris

Paris was declared an open city on 12 June. The Germans entered the capital early in the morning of 14 June. The Nazi flag went up everywhere — on the Élysée Palace, all along Rue de Rivoli, on the Arc de Triomphe, on the Eiffel Tower.



The Nazi flag flying over the Arc de Triomphe, June 1940.

German military headquarters were set up in the Crillon hotel, on Place de la Concorde. On the morning of 15 June, every German unit paraded down the Champs-Élysées to show the world that Paris had fallen.

A week later, Hitler made his only ever visit to Paris. He arrived around 6 a.m. on 23 June, toured the city — the Opéra, the Trocadéro, Napoleon's tomb at the Invalides — and was gone by 9 a.m. Three hours in the city he had dreamed of conquering his whole adult life.



Hitler at the Trocadéro, 23 June 1940 — the most reproduced image of his only visit to Paris.



Hitler at the Trocadéro with the Eiffel Tower behind him.

And finally, on 22 June 1940, France signed the armistice. Hitler had it signed in the very same railway carriage in the Compiègne forest where the Germans had signed in 1918. The carriage was then taken to Berlin as a trophy.



France divided after the armistice: occupied zone (north and west), "free" zone under Vichy (south), and the annexed Alsace-Moselle.

WALK — From the Palais du Luxembourg, head east on Rue de Vaugirard, then turn left onto Rue de l'Odéon. Stop in front of the Théâtre de l'Odéon — this is your next stop. About 4 minutes' walk.

INTERSTOP

Théâtre de l'Odéon — Plaque to Jacques Guierre

On the left-hand side of the theatre



WHERE TO LOOK

As you walk past the Théâtre de l'Odéon, look at the left-hand side of the building. You will see a small commemorative plaque set into the stone.

This plaque is dedicated to Jacques Guierre, an FFI fighter — Forces Françaises de l'Intérieur, the interior resistance forces — who was killed on this square at the age of 20, on the morning of 25 August 1944.

It is a fitting introduction to what is coming next. The FFI didn't fight a conventional battle. Their role during the insurrection was to disrupt the Germans as much as possible — and crucially, to gather intelligence and pass it to the Allies, so that the French and American armies could enter Paris with some idea of what they were walking into.

Jacques Guierre was barely 20 years old. He died on this square, on this very morning. The plaque is the only mark of it.



WALK — Continue down Rue de l'Odéon, then turn onto Rue Monsieur-le-Prince. Stop at the corner of Rue Monsieur-le-Prince and Rue de Vaugirard. About 3 minutes' walk.

STOP 3

The Beginnings of the Resistance

Rue Monsieur-le-Prince / Vaugirard — Agnès Humbert and the Musée de l'Homme network

📍 WHERE YOU STAND

You are at the corner of Rue Monsieur-le-Prince and Rue de Vaugirard, in the 6th arrondissement. Nothing here marks the spot — and that is partly the point.

In the autumn of 1940, a small group of Paris intellectuals began meeting in this neighbourhood to plan what would become France's first organised resistance network. These streets, this quarter — they were the kind of unremarkable Left Bank backstreets where a resistance cell could meet without drawing attention.

We're going to tell you the story of one of those meetings, and of the woman at its centre.

Agnès Humbert



Agnès Humbert (1894–1963) — art historian, museum curator, and one of the founders of the first organised resistance network in Paris.

At the previous stop we left things on 14 June 1940 — the day Paris fell. Eight days later, on 22 June, France signed the armistice. After that, slowly, the Parisians who had fled south started coming home. So did the staff of the great Paris museums, including Agnès Humbert, an art historian working at the Musée National des Arts et Traditions Populaires.

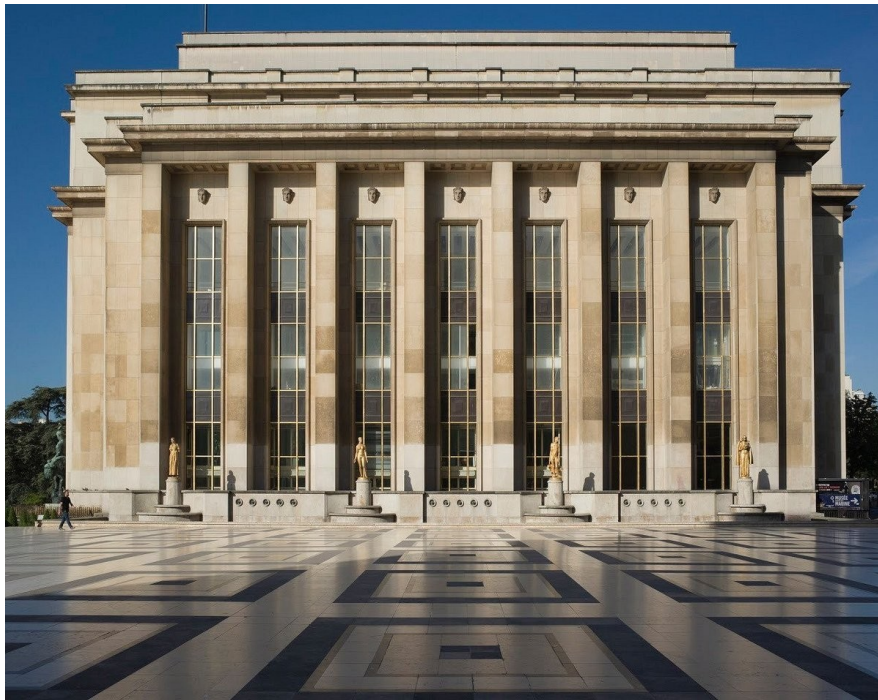
She returned at the beginning of August 1940. Very quickly, she noticed what had changed.

? What do you think were the main changes inside the French museums under occupation?

→ Everything was now labelled in German on top of French. Museums were free of charge for German soldiers. And entire exhibitions had been altered or removed — photographs of the USSR that Agnès Humbert had taken were gone, as were photos of the 1936 French general strikes. The Occupation reached into every institution.

Why the museums mattered

Before we get to the resistance network itself, a word about why museums sit at the heart of this story. Every great Paris museum was caught up in the war. The Jeu de Paume, just over the river, became the central depot for art looted from Jewish collections across Europe. Hermann Göring — the second man of the Reich — visited the Jeu de Paume at least twenty times, hand-picking the pieces he wanted shipped to Germany.



The Musée de l'Homme at the Trocadéro — the museum that gave its name to the network.

Across town, at the Trocadéro, the Musée de l'Homme — an anthropology museum opened just three years earlier — became something stranger: a meeting point for intellectuals who refused to accept the Occupation. The network we're about to talk about was named after it.

"It's as if we were rats in a trap"

Agnès Humbert wrote those words in her diary that summer. She had decided she could not live with the Occupation. The question was — what to do about it?

When you decide to resist, the first thing you do is look for allies. That's exactly what she did. Her closest ally was Jean Cassou, a friend and fellow museum curator. Together they began meeting trusted acquaintances, one by one.



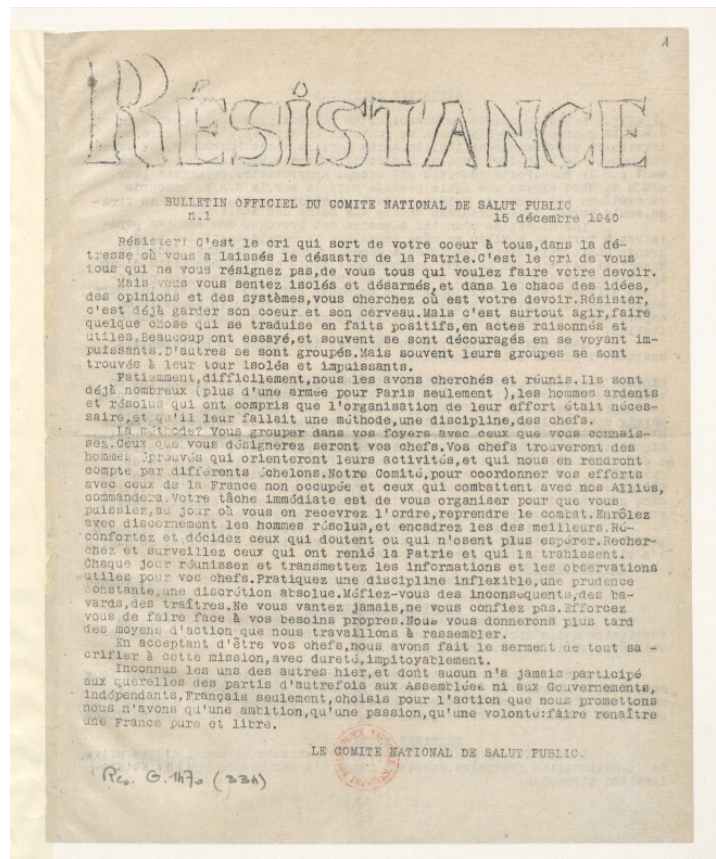
Jean Cassou — writer, art historian, co-founder of the Musée de l'Homme network.

By early September 1940, they had gathered a small group of around ten people they trusted absolutely. They met every week, often at 14 Rue de l'Abbaye in the 6th arrondissement — a few streets from where you're standing. At their meeting place, even the small detail of the clock mattered: it was kept on French time, not on the German time the Occupation had imposed across France. A tiny, daily act of defiance.

From scraps of paper to a clandestine newspaper

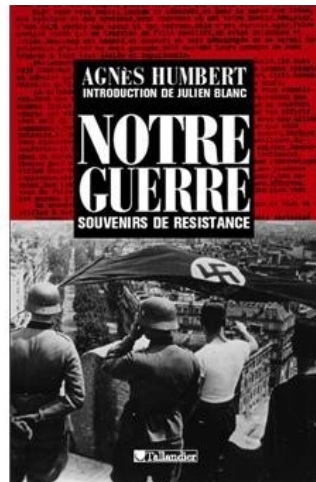
Their goal was to inform. They wanted to publish a clandestine newspaper — to tell Parisians the truths the censored press would not. They started small: hand-written notes on scraps of paper, left on metro benches, in mailboxes, on café tables. By the end of September they had a roneo, an early stencil duplicator, and could produce dozens of copies at once.

On 15 December 1940, the group published the first edition of their clandestine newspaper. They called it *Résistance* — and the word would stick. After the war, this is what we would call the whole movement.



*The first issue of *Résistance*, December 1940. The newspaper that gave the entire French resistance its name.*

They wrote about the military situation as they understood it; messages of hope and motivation; and on the practical side, detailed accounts of how French food was being shipped to Germany — precise counts of cows, pigs, chickens, and wine taken from French farms. The point was to make Parisians see what occupation actually was, beneath the polite surface.



Notre Guerre — Agnès Humbert's diary, published in 1946.

How many editions before they were caught?

The newspaper was meant to come out every two weeks. They managed just four editions before the network was dismantled. By early 1941 the Gestapo had arrived in Paris and was focusing on networks like this one. The problem with the Musée de l'Homme network was that it was growing fast — absorbing smaller networks, diversifying its work. At one point Agnès Humbert hid a Polish pilot. The network was also brought plans of a German submarine base on the Atlantic coast by a French officer.

And eventually — as is almost always the case with networks that grow too quickly — they brought in someone they should not have trusted. His name was Albert Gaveau. He worked for the Gestapo. One by one, people began to be arrested. Agnès Humbert was arrested on 13 April 1941.

The Germans came for her at the hospital where she was visiting her mother. They drove her home and searched her flat. She was interrogated at the Gestapo headquarters on Rue des Saussaies, then moved through a series of Paris prisons. The network was destroyed. She survived the camps, returned to France after the war, published her diary as *Notre Guerre* in 1946, and lived quietly until her death in 1963.

 **WALK** — From here, head north on Rue Monsieur-le-Prince towards the Sorbonne. About 3 minutes' walk. Stop in front of the main Sorbonne building. From this point you have three short interstops before the final stop facing Notre-Dame.

INTERSTOP

Sorbonne — Bullet holes on the main façade

In front of the Sorbonne — pay attention to the right-hand column



WHERE TO LOOK

Stand in front of the Sorbonne's main entrance. Pay close attention to the right-hand column.

The bullet holes are still there — Liberation-week scars that the university has chosen never to repair. They go up several metres.

The Latin Quarter — and the Sorbonne in particular — became one of the most important pockets of fighting on the Left Bank during the August 1944 insurrection. Students, FFI fighters, and ordinary Parisians made these streets some of the fiercest battlegrounds of the week. The bullet holes on this column are a direct reminder of that.



WALK — Walk around the Sorbonne to the other side of the building. Find the observatory tower.

INTERSTOP

Sorbonne Observatory Tower

Other side of the Sorbonne — look up



WHERE TO LOOK

Stand at the base of the Sorbonne observatory tower. Look up at the stonework.

The tower is covered in bullet holes — far more visible than on the main façade. Take a moment to count them.

This was one of the most important nests of fighting on the Left Bank during the insurrection. The tower offered height and a clear line of fire — exactly what both German troops and resistance fighters wanted control of. The marks you can see are what remains of those days.



WALK — Head north on Rue Saint-Jacques towards the river. Turn right onto Rue Galande and continue to the small square in front of the Église Saint-

Séverin. About 5 minutes.

INTERSTOP

Église Saint-Séverin — The barricades

In front of the church — same spot, 80 years apart

WHERE TO LOOK

You are now in front of the Église Saint-Séverin, one of the oldest churches on the Left Bank, on Rue du Petit-Pont.

Compare the street you are standing on with the photograph below — it was taken right here in August 1944.



Barricade on Rue du Petit-Pont, in front of Saint-Séverin church — August 1944. Same spot, 80 years later.

More than 600 barricades were built across Paris during the insurrection week. They were made of cobblestones, café tables, café chairs, café signs, mattresses, doors — anything heavy enough to slow a German tank. The Germans had about 22,000 men and 100 tanks in Paris that week. The barricades were a logistical nightmare for them: every time they tried to move armour across the city, they had to send infantry first to dismantle blockages, often under fire from the windows above.



Barricade at 30 Rue Saint-Jacques, a few streets from here. Witnesses called it the most elegant barricade of the insurrection — built by the architecture students of Paris.

 **WALK** — Walk towards the river. Cross the bridge onto the Île de la Cité, then stop on the parvis facing Notre-Dame — with the Préfecture de Police clearly visible on your left, on the same island. About 2 minutes.

STOP 4

The Liberation of Paris

Facing Notre-Dame — The Préfecture de Police and the insurrection of August 1944



WHERE YOU STAND

You are facing Notre-Dame, with the Île de la Cité in front of you. But the building this stop is really about is the one immediately to the right of Notre-Dame, on the same Île de la Cité: the Préfecture de Police de Paris.

The Préfecture was the first stronghold seized by the resistance during the insurrection of August 1944. It is where the Liberation of Paris really began.

Paris could have been Warsaw

Before we get into what happened here, you need to understand the broader picture. Paris in August 1944 came terrifyingly close to suffering the same fate as Warsaw.

Warsaw's insurrection began on 1 August 1944, just three weeks before the Paris uprising. It lasted more than 60 days. By the end, 18,000 Polish soldiers and 170,000 civilians were dead. 85% of the city was destroyed. The Soviets, who were within striking distance, did not come to the Poles' aid.

Now look at Paris in August 1944:

- A city occupied by the Nazis
- An insurrection started by its own people
- Allies who were not originally planning to liberate the city
- A new German commander appointed by a dictator with nothing left to lose

Sounds familiar?



Why didn't the Allies plan to liberate Paris straight away?

→ Three reasons. One — the fear of street-by-street fighting like Stalingrad, costly in both soldiers and civilians. Two — Paris was not strategically essential. Going through it would delay the American advance on Berlin, where the race against the Soviets had become the priority. Three — the logistical nightmare of suddenly having to feed 3 million starving Parisians once the city was liberated.

And yet, the Allies came

The Allies had landed in Normandy on 6 June 1944, and the original plan was to sweep east straight for Berlin, bypassing Paris. What changed their minds was the insurrection itself, and what Raoul Nordling — the Swedish consul, more on him in a

minute — was able to tell Eisenhower about Von Choltitz. By 22 August, the decision had been taken: Leclerc and his men would rush in. The French 2nd Armoured Division and the US 4th Infantry Division would come to Paris' aid.

The main characters

Let me introduce you to the protagonists of that terrible week in Paris.

On the German side: General Dietrich von Choltitz, brought to Paris by Hitler himself on 10 August. His mission: keep Paris German, and crush any insurrection without mercy.



General Dietrich von Choltitz — German commander of "Greater Paris", August 1944.

On the French side, two camps were already competing for political power after Paris would be liberated:

- The Communists, who led most of the resistance fighters inside Paris.
- The Gaullists, loyal to General Charles de Gaulle. They controlled most of the police force inside Paris, and crucially they had General Philippe Leclerc — who was leading De Gaulle's French 2nd Armoured Division, cruising eastward alongside the Allies after the Normandy landings of 6 June 1944.



Colonel Henri Rol-Tanguy — Communist regional leader of the FFI, who would force the insurrection.

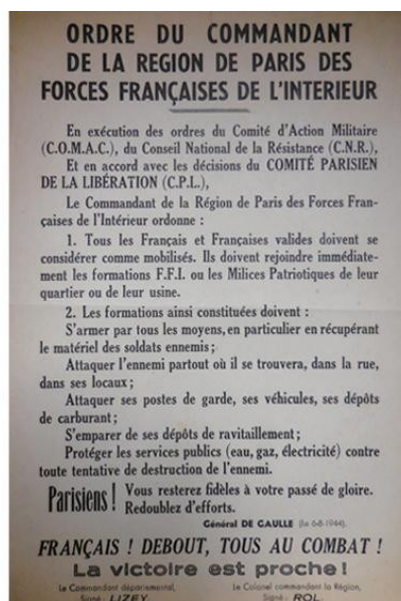


General Philippe Leclerc — commander of the French 2nd Armoured Division, who would lead the Allied push into Paris.

19 August 1944 — The insurrection begins

By mid-August, Paris was boiling. The police, the gas workers, the electricity workers, the transport workers were all on strike. The Germans were openly preparing to defend the city. Von Choltitz had told the mayor of Paris that he was ready to destroy every bridge in the city and every power station.

The Gaullists wanted to delay the insurrection — it would be a bloodbath for Parisians. The Communists wanted to launch it immediately, to take political control of the city by force of arms. The Communists got their way. The insurrection began on 19 August 1944 — the 1,518th day of the German occupation.



The call to insurrection plastered on Paris walls, August 1944.

The Préfecture de Police — first stronghold

Even though the Communists had wanted to fire the first shot, the Gaullists heard about it and moved fast. It would have been too dangerous to let the Communists alone claim the symbol of the insurrection. So a senior policeman, Yves Bayet, led the Paris police force in seizing the Préfecture de Police for General de Gaulle. He then walked to the terrace of the café Les Deux Magots and told Charles Luizet — De Gaulle's trusted lieutenant, parachuted into France just seven days earlier — that the Préfecture was his.

First gunfire in Paris since 1871

It was the first time the sound of gunfire and gunpowder had echoed through Paris since the Commune of 1871. At 3:30 p.m., the Germans sent the tanks. Two Panthers and a captured Renault rolled onto the parvis of Notre-Dame — directly in front of you, where the tourists now stand — and opened fire. The main door of the Préfecture exploded.

Von Choltitz, Nordling, and the truce

Faced with this open revolt, Von Choltitz had to act fast. His plan: a Luftwaffe air strike on the Préfecture at 4 a.m. on 20 August, followed by a ground assault by the tanks. The Préfecture would be flattened.

It didn't happen. The Swedish consul-general in Paris, Raoul Nordling, intervened and proposed a ceasefire that suited both sides — Von Choltitz needed time to consolidate, the resistance needed to resupply. The truce was agreed.

It did not hold. The Communists pushed hard against it — they wanted the insurrection to keep its momentum. Rol-Tanguy, that day, said the line that would become famous: "Paris is worth 200,000 dead."

All over Paris, the city organised for war: clandestine printing presses now produced flyers with Molotov cocktail recipes; pharmacies, which stocked potassium chlorate, became improvised arsenals; the flats of resistance medical students became field hospitals.



The clandestine press of those days — calling Parisians "To the barricades!"

22-23 August — The decision to send Leclerc

On the night of 22 August, after Nordling crossed the Allied lines and pleaded with Eisenhower and Bradley, the decision was finally taken: the French 2nd Armoured Division under General Leclerc, supported by the US 4th Infantry, would rush to Paris. Leclerc had been ordered to wait. He started moving anyway.

On 23 August, Von Choltitz received a direct order from Hitler himself. If the Allies were to reach Paris, they should find only ruins. Across the city, the explosives were already in place: the 42 bridges, the Parliament, the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, the Luxembourg Palace, the two hotels on Place de la Concorde, the Invalides. Everything was wired. Choltitz was waiting on the final order.

24 August — The plane mission to the Préfecture

By the morning of 24 August, the situation for the resistance fighters inside the Préfecture was desperate. They were almost out of ammunition. Luizet and his deputy Pisani called the police station in Longjumeau, 35 km south of Paris, to ask where the Allied divisions were. The man on the other end held the phone to the window and said: "Can you hear that? They're right here."

And then there is a story I really want to tell you.

On the afternoon of 24 August, hours before the Allied tanks would enter the city, General Leclerc ordered two French pilots to carry out an extraordinary mission. Their job: fly over Paris and drop a written message into the courtyard of the Préfecture de Police, to tell the resistance fighters inside: hold on, we are coming.



Jean Callet — pilot of the Piper Cub mission, 24 August 1944.



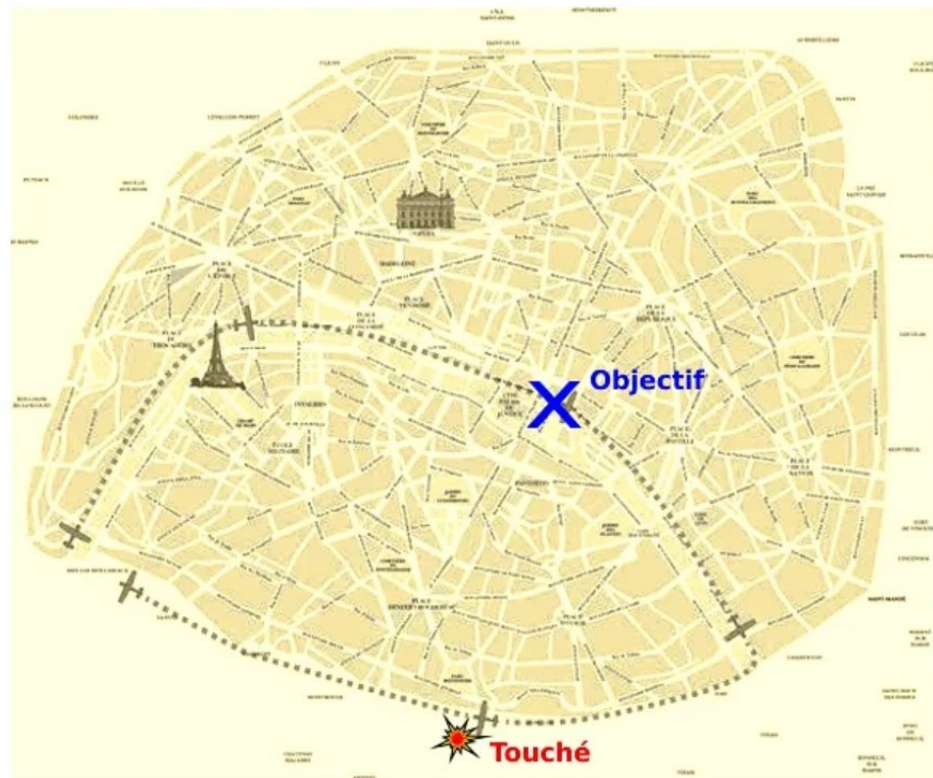
Étienne Mantoux — observer aboard the Piper Cub. He would not survive the war.



A Piper Cub — the type of light aircraft used for the mission.

Captain Jean Callet was the pilot. Lieutenant Étienne Mantoux was in the back, holding the message. The mission launched around 5 p.m. They flew low, hiding in the clouds where they could. By 6 p.m. they were over Paris and could see the objective ahead — but the Germans could see them too.

Eight hundred metres from the Préfecture, as Callet was following the Seine, he abruptly nosed the plane into a dive. He wanted the Germans to think he'd been hit and was crashing, to make them stop firing. At the last possible moment, he pulled up — and Mantoux, in the back, dropped the message. It landed inside the Préfecture courtyard.



The flight path of the mission — over Paris, towards the Préfecture, and back.

THESE SPACES FOR MESSAGE CENTER ONLY	
TIME FILED	MSD CEN
MESSAGE (SUBMIT TO MESSAGE CENTER IN DUPLICATE) (CLASSIFICATION)	
No 4	DATE 24 Août 1944
To FFI Préfecture de Police Paris	
Le Général LECLERC vous	
fait dire :	
Très bon, nous suivons	
Lt Colonel C ^t l'artillerie 2 ^e DB	
OFFICIAL DESIGNATION OF WRITER	
AUTHORIZED TO BE	TIME 16.50
SEND IN CLEAR	SIGNATURE OF OFFICER
SIGNATURE AND GRADE OF WRITER	
Lt Col CREPIN	

The message dropped by Mantoux into the Préfecture courtyard, signed by Leclerc.

2^e DIVISION BLINDÉE
 25^e S.O.A.A.
 N° 2177/AD
 143 29 911

Le 24 Aout 1944

MISSION N° 30

BdE
 Del. 2
 Chm. 2
 5000/1004

5/1

EQUIPAGE	Fonction	N° de l'appareil	Depart: Arriv:	Nature de la mission
capitaine CALLET	Pilote	Piper-cub	18 h.30:18h.35	Lancer sur la préfecture de Police de Paris
lieut. MANTOUX	Observateur	n° 911		occupe par le FFI, un message au Général LE CLERC, Secrétaire de la naissance sur l'itinéraire PARIS-JOUR-PAIS LONJUMEAU

Conditions atmosphériques : Temps nettement dégagé dans la soirée. Visibilité de 25 à 30 kilomètres. Vent nul au sol. Pluie 1.000 mètres. Cumulus de beau temps.

Incidents mécaniques survenus en vol : 1) Roue gauche: pneu crevé par éclat D.C.A.
 2) Pantalon droit du train d'atterrissage perforé par éclat. Rupture de la canalisation d'huile du frein droit.

Impression d'ensemble : Excellente visibilité permettant continuité de l'observation en vol.

Versus aller : Sur la route ARPAGON - LONJUMEAU - PARIS -, après Longjumeau occupé par les troupes Françaises, pas de blindés ennemis visibles. Aucune réaction de la D.C.A. ennemie. Pas de chasse ennemie. L'avion manœuvra au ras du plafond et par intermittence dans les nuages.

Objectif : Le message est lancé à 18 h. 30. Aucune circulation dans les rues de l'île St Louis et l'île de la Cité, sauf quelques promeneurs sur le quai d'Anjou. Plusieurs uniformes allemands sur la rive gauche. Tir nourri d'armes légères au moment du passage au-dessus de la Seine.

Versus retour : Vive réaction de D.C.A. dans les régions des Gobelins, Kremlin - Biotre - Arcueil - Cachan - Villejuif, 13 points d'atterrissage de l'appareil se répartissent de la manière suivante : 2 dans le train d'atterrissage, 1 dans le plan fixe gauche, 2 dans le gouvernail de profondeur, 1 dans l'aile gauche, 2 dans le plan gauche, 2 dans l'aile droite, 3 dans le plan gauche.

The official report of the mission, filed after the pilots' return.

Getting away, they flew as close to the rooftops as they dared, zigzagging hard. The landing gear of the Piper was shot up over southern Paris. The plane had 13 bullet holes when they finally landed in a field in Allied-held territory, tipped over on its right wing.

Jean Callet survived the war and became a general in the French army. He died in 2006. Étienne Mantoux was not so lucky — he was killed on 29 April 1945, less than ten days before Victory in Europe.

24 August at night — The bells of Paris

At 9:22 p.m. on 24 August, the first detachment of the French 2nd Armoured Division, led by Captain Raymond Dronne, reached the Hôtel de Ville. The resistance fighters inside burst into La Marseillaise. The song spread to the streets. On the radio, an announcer asked all the priests of Paris to ring their bells — for the first time in four years, since they had stayed silent throughout the Occupation. The great 13-tonne bell of Notre-Dame, the one named Emmanuel, the one directly in front of you now, rang out around 9:30 p.m.

25 August — Liberation

On the morning of 25 August, the French 2nd Armoured Division and the US 4th Infantry made their proper entrance into Paris. The streets erupted. Parisians threw everything they had — fruit, cheese, bottles of wine and champagne saved for exactly this moment — at the soldiers. Some tanks were reportedly slowed down by the sheer weight of civilians climbing onto them.



German soldiers being marched out of the Hôtel Meurice, Von Choltitz's headquarters, on 25 August 1944.



General de Gaulle descending the Champs-Élysées, 26 August 1944. "Paris liberated! By itself, by its people, with the help of the armies of France, with the support and help of all of France."

The end of the tour

This is where our tour ends — facing Notre-Dame, with the Préfecture de Police that started the insurrection just over the river, and the cathedral whose bells rang to mark the moment the Liberation became real.

You've walked across three districts and roughly five years of history: from a quiet Boulevard Saint-Michel before the war, through the fall of Paris in 35 days, the patient work of the first resistance networks, the bullet-scarred Sorbonne quarter, and the strange, joyful, bloody insurrection of August 1944.

If this tour added something to your stay in Paris, the best thing you can do for me is leave a short review on Google. And if you would like to walk it again with me in person — where I share the smaller human stories, the digressions and details I keep for the live tour — everything is on parishistorytours.com.

Thank you for walking with me.

— Clément